

Re: Reading assignment - Courage

Name/Email: Shaira Katuwal, skatuwal@iu.edu

Team 9

Date: 1st February, 2026

As someone who constantly overthinks and runs a question in their mind thrice before saying it out loud in class, out of the fear that it would sound “stupid”, the essay on “Courage” is very relatable and reflective. It also serves as a great expansion on the last reading, “All-In,” where I mentioned how the state of being “all-in” can be very confusing. I discussed whether all-in is a stable state or something that a team moves in and out of, and what leads to such a difference in effort. After reading the essay today, I believe courage could very well be the answer to the question I posed in my last writing. This reading explores the key to stability during those ups and downs. It suggests how this can not only be based on technical abilities but also on a particular kind of bravery. The reading challenged me to look beyond team diversity as just a “mix of work styles” and see it as a shared commitment to a “covenant” (Courage, 2018, p. 2).

The core of this writing is around the idea that “more important than the will to win is the courage to begin” (Courage, 2018, p. 8). In finance classes, we often focus on the perfect model, the successful pitch, the depth in the slide deck, but we often forget about the human behind all this and what it truly means for that human to be in the presenter’s seat.

The biggest takeaway on courage can be applied to the first challenge we encountered, which is the outreach for a project sponsor. The fear of presenting to someone new, of getting rejected, not being able to come up with ideas, or simply not being able to communicate effectively, might all be signs of being “painfully unprepared” (Courage, 2018, p. 14). The reading emphasizes that this fear and anxiety are very normal. We worry a lot about what might go wrong, we invest time to visualize the worse and in that time, all we gain is fear, fear that replaces courage and that pulls you away from your chances to succeed. Had you invested the same time to read, think, and write about your pitch, you could have replaced the fear with certainty and pulled the lever towards the courage to fly.

More than trying and failing, what really has a bigger negative impact on the team is your integrity. One of the toughest questions that the reading raises is how we deal with failure. Telling teammates that I missed on delivering to a sponsor is, in fact, a great example of showcasing real integrity, your ability to accept failure, and learn from it. It might be tempting to hide your mistakes, but at the end of the day, it is only human to make those mistakes. I learned that in a team setting, having members with the courage to own their mistakes can in fact be a great sign of strength. I will make sure that in any role I play in the team, I will demand honesty even when it's tough, and honor my part of the deal the same way.

Lastly, I want to circle back to how I began my writing about speaking up in the classroom and the constant war I play inside my head before I speak. After this reading, I realise that if I can find the courage to trust my own insights (Courage, 2018, p. 27), I can move beyond relying on stiff notes and tap into that "mysterious force" of true confidence. The same logic applied to my contribution to my team will hopefully help us explore numerous ideas and allow a safer space for all members to speak up confidently.

So to answer the question, "To begin what?" to begin the shift from being a student who takes on a task, delivers, and moves on to the next, to a professional who leads with character. As I look forward to the rest of the course, I will be working hard to not only get my team to be all-in but also to have the courage to begin, to open the car door, and to confront whatever challenge lies ahead.